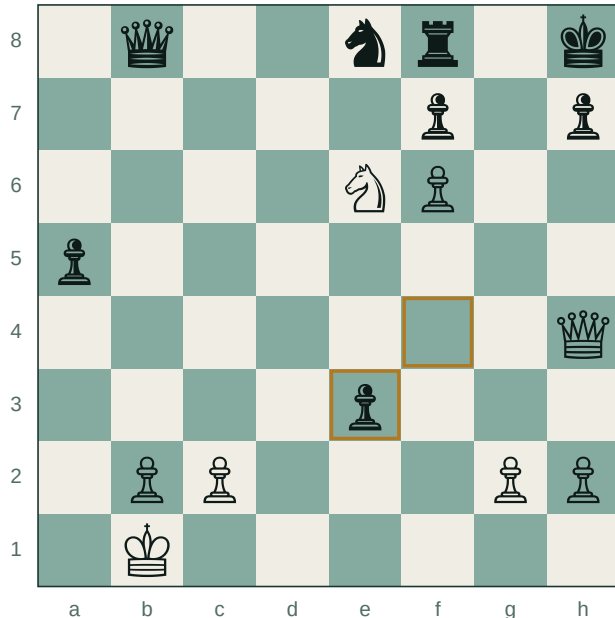


Loose-piece tactics: White, move 33

Loose-piece tactics

White to move



Previous move: 32...fxe3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

33. Nxf8 Nxf6 34. Qxf6+

33.Nxf8 The knight captures the rook on f8. Recorded reply: **33...Nxf6**.

34.Qxf6+ Check restricts Black to 1 legal reply here. The move also takes the knight on f6.

At the end, nominal material is White 16 / Black 13 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +7. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +7: the balance goes from -4 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A piece may appear hanging because its defender is indirect: taking it might allow mate, a fork, or a stronger capture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

An undefended or tactically undefendable piece can turn an ordinary position into a combination. The first task is to distinguish a truly free capture from a poisoned one.

HOW TO LOOK

List the loose enemy pieces and check whether a forcing move can expose or attack more than one of them.

The defending king is on h8. Absolute pin: pawn on h7.